

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

THE SIMS PRIORITY GAP

Did The Sims 4 Forget How to Simulate Life?
10+ Years of Data Says Yes

Full Project Available on [GitHub](#) | Dashboard Available on [Tableau](#)

Author	Project Type	Tools	Completion Date
Alana Henry	Strategic Gap Analysis & Product Audit	Excel & Tableau Public	April 2026

Problem Statement

The Sims 4 is marketed as a life simulation game but does its paid content actually reflect that? This project uses 10+ years of DLC data to find out whether EA's content strategy matches the game's core premise, and whether players asking for a deeper simulation are getting what they paid for.

Methodology

I manually built three datasets:

1. A complete log of all 98 paid DLC packs classified as either Simulation-Rich or Aesthetic using a defined rubric.
2. A log of 17 simulation features customers/players have been repeatedly requesting online, tracking how long EA has gone without adding them.
3. A feature comparison of 23 simulation categories across 6 game versions (including new competitors)

All analysis was done in Microsoft Excel. The findings are presented across seven interactive visualizations published on Tableau Public.

Key Findings

- **The Big Split:** 61.2% of all 98 paid DLC packs released are classified as Aesthetic (content that only adds visual items like clothes or furniture).
- **The Kit Effect:** Since Kits launched in 2021, Aesthetic content has made up over 70% of all new releases in every single year (with the exception of 2025 where it fell to 66.67%)
- **The Retail Value Split:** The cumulative retail value of all Aesthetic packs is \$418.40 across 60 packs. The cumulative retail value of all Simulation-Rich packs is \$1,089.62 across only 38 packs. EA released more than half the catalogue in the lower-value category.

- **The Total Bill:** A player who bought every paid pack since launch to March 2026 would have spent \$1,568.01.
- **Still Waiting:** The community has been requesting Open World, a Colour Wheel, and several other Core features since 2014 but they remain absent in 2026 (12 years later).
- **The Competition:** inZoi launched in 2025 with open world navigation, driveable cars, and a colour wheel included in the base game for \$39.99 with no paid DLC.

Conclusion

The data consistently shows that the majority of paid DLC released for The Sims 4 between 2014 and 2026 was Aesthetic in nature, and that proportion grew significantly over time, especially after 2021. The data answers the central question clearly; EA's paid content strategy shifted away from simulation depth and toward high-volume visual content, while simulation features players asked for went unaddressed for over a decade.